

## World in Brief: French court blocks social-media ban; sharp decline in American violent crime



Photograph: Photothek via Getty Images

A court in **France** blocked a bill that would prohibit under-15s from using [social media](#). The Constitutional Council ruled that a ban would infringe on children's freedom of speech and communication. Australia brought in a similar ban in December. Meta, which owns Facebook and Instagram, said this week it had taken down 750,000 accounts of Australians it believed to be under age.

American **crime statistics** show the largest year-to-year decline in violent crime since FBI records began in 1936. Murder and non-negligent manslaughter decreased by 18.1% in 2025 while robberies fell by 18.5%. Violent crime overall fell by 9.3% and property crime by 12.4%. Donald Trump tried to take some credit, but [Democrats](#) pointed out that the fall began before his return to office.

Mr Trump told Americans that it is worth paying “a tiny little bit more for your gasoline” to ensure that “a very evil country” does not obtain nuclear weapons. Average **petrol prices** in America are \$4.08 per gallon, [up](#) nearly 30% on a year ago. Meanwhile, Iran's deputy foreign minister said America should accept defeat in the

stand-off. He tweeted that the Strait of Hormuz “will be opened and closed only under Iran’s command”.

Japan’s defence minister visited **Yasukuni shrine** in Tokyo on the 81st anniversary of his country’s wartime surrender. Koizumi Shinjiro said he visited the shrine to offer his condolences and express respect, and that he renewed his pledge “never to wage war again”. Most [senior leaders](#) avoid the site, which honours Japan’s war dead. China, South Korea and others see it as a symbol of past militarism.

**Jason Arday**, a Cambridge University professor who resigned amid a plagiarism row, was found dead in London. Police are treating his death as “unexpected” but not suspicious. Mr Arday, who was 41, became the university’s youngest-ever black professor in 2023. An investigation had recently been launched of allegations that he had copied others’ work and exaggerated his qualifications. Mr Arday said the accusations were racially motivated.

**Luigi Mangione** admitted to [fatally shooting Brian Thompson](#), the boss of UnitedHealthcare, America’s biggest health insurer, in Manhattan in 2024. He also pleaded guilty to two federal charges of stalking. Mr Mangione will be sentenced in December and faces life in prison. His lawyers are now seeking to dismiss a separate state murder charge in New York, for which a trial is scheduled next month.

A group of investors that includes **Jeff Bezos**, the founder of Amazon, agreed to buy a minority stake in **Liverpool Football Club**, said Fenway Sports Group, its majority owner. They will acquire a stake of roughly a third, according to reports. The deal could raise Liverpool’s valuation to \$7.5bn, among the highest for a [football club](#).

**Word of the week:** Pyrocumulonimbus. Towering, smoke-tinged storm clouds that form above wildfires, supercharging them. [Read](#)

[about how](#) researchers are collecting samples from these little-understood weather events.

Have you been following the headlines? Test your knowledge of the news with [our weekly quiz](#).

# Happy independence day to India's Gen Z



Photograph: Getty Images

India gained independence from Britain on August 15th 1947. Yet some figures within the country's ruling outfit, the Bharatiya Janata Party, controversially claim that it won true independence only in 2014—the year the BJP began its current period of rule. This Saturday [Narendra Modi](#), the prime minister, stuck to the official timeline, delivering a speech from the ramparts of Old Delhi's Red Fort to mark India's independence day.

This year's programme celebrates India's youth. Those invited include precocious overachievers, such as medalists from the international maths olympiad and interns from the prime minister's office. Self-described “cockroaches” have been left off the list. Last month mass protests by the upstart youth movement, [the Cockroach Janta Party](#), forced the resignation of India's education minister over corruption in entry exams into medical college. India's new age of accountability has spooked Mr Modi into cosyng up to the next generation.

# China sets sail on the “Ice Silk Road”



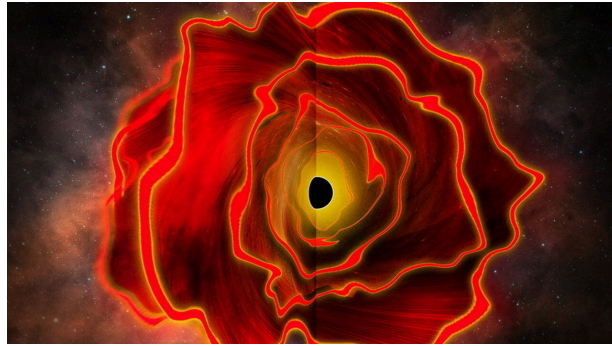
Photograph: Reuters

This weekend Sea Legend, a Chinese shipping company, begins the first regular service along the Northern Sea Route, which crosses the Arctic by skirting the Russian coast. Running between Ningbo, eastern China, and Felixstowe in Britain, the service is expected to take 20 days—roughly half the usual transit time via the Suez Canal.

Tariffs and global conflicts have increased interest in alternative shipping routes. A warming Arctic makes the region [more viable](#) for commercial transit. But the NSR is not without challenges. The route is seasonal: most voyages can be made only in the summer, when there is less ice. And access is controlled by Rosatom, a Russian state-owned firm. That worries European shipping companies, some of whom have pledged to avoid it. Still, Sea Legend will soon be followed by others. PanStar, a South Korean shipping company, begins a trial voyage later this month.



# How the universe got its spots



Photograph: Jose-Luis Olivares/MIT

Astronomers have spent two years squabbling over a collection of “little red dots” in the sky. First spotted in 2024 by the [James Webb Space Telescope](#), these mysterious red pinpoints of bright light formed when the universe was only around 660m years old (today the cosmic codger is around 14bn). But scientists cannot agree on what they actually are.

A new paper in *Nature* this week offers some clarity. Researchers studied a particularly strange red dot called MOM-BH\*-1, determining it to be a black hole in a shroud of dense, turbulent gas. That gas could be fuelling its rapid growth, explaining how the universe’s first black holes got so big. The debate is by no means settled. But their findings suggest the little red dots could be “black hole stars”—hypothetical objects that are the progenitors of the supermassive black holes which sit at the centre of galaxies today.



# Netflix adapts an Australian feminist classic



Photograph: Netflix

Miles Franklin, an Australian author, wrote “My Brilliant Career” when she was 16 years old. Published in 1901, the novel follows a rural teenager as she tries to rebel against conventions of class and gender to pursue her dream of becoming a writer. But the book’s semi-autobiographical nature led to unwanted scrutiny for Franklin, who withdrew it from publication. Since she died, in 1954, it has become a feminist classic. This week Netflix released an adaptation.

The television series has all the hallmarks of a Netflix period drama: stylish production, raging hormones and historical characters who share the vocabulary and sensibilities of their modern audience. Franklin certainly wouldn’t have recognised the soundtrack, which includes covers of songs by artists such as Blondie. But she probably would have found its women-led production team pleasing. Franklin endowed one of Australia’s top literary prizes; in a nod to her, Netflix has launched its own initiative to support young Australian women writers.



## Weekend profile: Rob Sand, Democrats' best hope in Iowa



Photograph: Reuters

Last month, at a Methodist church in the middle of Iowa, Rob Sand handed a microphone to his internet troll. “Gary, good to see you,” the Democratic candidate for governor said. He probably meant it. By showing up to the town hall, Gary Leffler, a Republican activist known across the state for driving a Trump-themed tractor, gave Mr Sand the chance to put his money where his mouth is. “Talk is cheap, right?” said Mr Sand. He answered Mr Leffler’s questions thoughtfully.

Mr Sand’s town halls (he is about halfway through a tour of Iowa’s 99 counties) routinely feature Republicans, both supportive and sceptical—as well as a group sing-a-long of “America the Beautiful”. He talks up bipartisanship but actually seems to favour nonpartisanship, accusing the Democratic and Republican Parties, the “two private clubs” running American politics, of exploiting divisions to “pick our pockets”. The earnest schtick seems to be working for Mr Sand; a recent Emerson College poll showed him leading his Republican opponent by five points with three months to go before the November election. In Iowa, which has not elected a Democratic governor in 20 years, that is a big deal. [Some Democrats are hopeful](#) that Mr Sand’s strong campaign will buoy other Democratic candidates in the state, too.

Polished and sharp, the 44-year-old Mr Sand balances his Ivy League degree and a short career as a model with serious Iowa credibility. Growing up, he made pocket money catching chickens, which is even worse than it sounds: rounding up terrified capons in dark barns and loading them onto lorries. (Defecating, he remembered, was their “last line of defence”.) He turned down Harvard Law to attend the University of Iowa, then prosecuted corruption cases, including one against a sprawling lottery-rigging ring. He claims that, in his current role as the state’s auditor, he already serves as a check on power.

Accountability, oversight and civilised debate are focal points of Mr Sand’s campaign. Republicans, who have controlled the governorship and legislature for a decade, have left Iowa in a bad way: young, educated people are leaving, the economy is slowing and public schools are consolidating. But Mr Sand, keenly aware that Republicans outnumber Democrats in the state, avoids villainising others. He argues that bad outcomes are the result of process failures. Anything or anyone can spoil after a while. The solution? It’s “called crop rotation”, he says. “And it works for politicians too.”

# Mini crossword

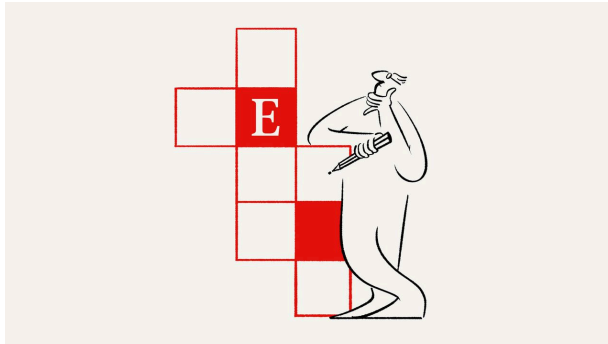


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

## Cryptic clues

*1 across* - Adam's son, I hear, is capable (4)

*2 across* - Alternatively in renown you'll find the light (4)

*3 across* - Two rings in a hermit state. A nice place to curl up with a book (4)

*1 down* - Hang fast, Ian. Bafflingly the Taliban are back in charge (11)

## Straight clues

*1 across* - With sufficient skill (4)

*2 across* - A glowing noble gas (4)

*3 across* - A cozy corner (4)

*1 down* - Country where the Taliban returned to power five years ago (11)

# The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

**Gordon Gray**, Virginia, America

**Martyn Beardsell**, Salzburg, Austria

**Sharon Neal**, London, Britain

They all gave the correct answers of: the Labour Party, the Albert memorial, Chris Columbus, Martin Luther King Jr and Independence, Missouri. The theme is us federal holidays; Labour Day, Memorial Day, Columbus Day, Martin Luther King Jr Day and Independence Day.

The questions were:

**Monday:** Which British political party, founded in 1900, produced prime ministers such as Ramsay MacDonald and Harold Wilson?

**Tuesday:** Which London landmark, designed by Sir George Gilbert Scott, features sculptures representing four continents, and four arts and sciences, as well as of the central figure it is named after?

**Wednesday:** Who directed the first two Harry Potter films?

**Thursday:** Which civil rights leader was baptised with the name of Michael, only to have his name changed by his father at the age of 5?

**Friday:** Which city is the site of the Truman Presidential Library?

*Look back, and smile on perils  
past!*

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***Sir Walter Scott***